Overview of the political landscape in southern Shan State

Lacking a clear candidate for co-optation, the political order in the southern Shan State presents a mixed picture made up of triangular interactions among Pa-O and Shan actors and the state. Conflict between Shan and Pa-O armed groups flare up regularly. For instance, in September 2014 the SSA fought with the PNLO. The SSA was accused of burning down new facilities built by the PNLO in Maukmae. As mentioned previously, the PNLO has no fixed territory, but the main population of Maukmae are Pa-O and the PNLO considers itself the "administrator" of the town. The PNLO obtained permission from the central government to build two complexes in the town for administrative purposes. In return, the PNLO allowed the government to use part of the buildings. The RCSS/SSA-S felt the presence of government officials was too close for comfort, so it burned the buildings down when they were around ninety per cent complete. Fighting between PNLO and SSA ensued, and only stopped when the government threatened to send in its own troops.[19]

The CSO activities are also causing tension. The USDP has been particularly annoyed by KRSAN; the group frequently holds gatherings outside the university, hospitals, and in public areas of Taunggyi to sing about democracy. It has called in the police to evict them on several occasions.[20] Likewise, a CSO report on land-grabbing and pollution caused by the Tigyit coal and power project brought considerable embarrassment to the pro-establishment camp (Pa-Oh Youth Organization and Kyoju Action Network 2011).[21]

Figure 5.4 shows the relationships between political actors in the southern Shan State, with solid lines representing a supportive relationship and dotted lines depicting conflicts. Patronage works in the Pa-O community because the PNO is the dominant actor, helped by the regime's divide-and-rule strategy. However, the same tactic has not been effective in the southern Shan State because there are no dominant actors to co-opt. Meanwhile, hostility remains both within and between groups. The PNO and PNLO are not on speaking terms, the PNLO is still fighting with the RCSS/SSA-S, and CSOs and political activists such as the 88 Generation Group are trying to undermine central authority.